

FEMALE PUBERTY

Changes to the female body are caused by the hormones oestrogen and progesterone. The first sign of puberty is the development of breasts, which starts around 10–11 years. Then hair grows in the armpits and pubic area. Leg hair thickens, and body shape



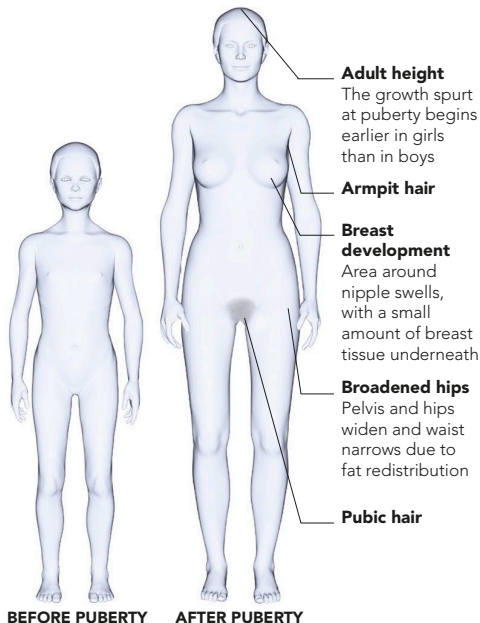
FOLLICLE IN AN OVARY

At puberty, the ovary starts to form mature follicles each containing a single egg (red).

changes as body fat increases. Hair and skin become oily, which may cause acne. Periods tend to begin at 12 to 13 years. Girls may experience mood swings and irritability.

CHANGES IN THE BODY

Growth rate peaks at about age 12, when girls grow up to 9cm (3½in) a year. Growth usually stops by the age of 16.



FEMALE HORMONE CONTROL

In the menstrual cycle, the hypothalamus releases gonadotropin-releasing hormone (GnRH) to trigger the pituitary to secrete luteinizing hormone (LH) and follicle-

stimulating hormone (FSH). These hormones control the activity of the ovaries and female hormones, and also send feedback (see p.139) to the hypothalamus and the pituitary gland.

